MCQ Teacher Guide

Building and running assessments on MCQ

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1. Getting started

MCQ is a place to write multiple-choice and short-answer assessments, assign them to your students, and see how everyone did. This guide covers everything a teacher needs.

Signing in

The sign-in page has two sides. Use the left panel, Teachers & administrators. Students use the right panel. If you sign in on the wrong side the page will tell you and point you to the other one.

Everyone signs in with Google, using their school account - there are no MCQ passwords. Signing in from the teacher panel the first time creates your teacher account straight away; there is no approval queue and nothing to wait for.

> *Note: Anyone can create a teacher account. Students, by contrast, must choose at least one teacher before they can do anything, so your students will need to find you by name or email.*

2. Your roster

Your roster is the list of students you teach. Only students on your roster can be assigned your assessments, and only their results appear in your analytics.

How students join you

1. A student signs in for the first time and is asked to choose a teacher.
2. They search for you by name or email and select you.
3. They appear on your roster immediately, and pick up any assessment you had already assigned to the whole class.

Adding students yourself

Open Students to add someone directly. Add an existing student to roster finds a student who already has an account. Add a new student creates the account from their name and email.

> *Note: A student you add this way signs in with Google using that same email address, and lands straight in your roster.*

Classes

Classes are named groups inside your roster - a section, for example. Once a class exists you can assign a whole assessment to it in one click. Create and fill classes on the Students page, under Classes.

- Sort students - a table of your whole roster with a Class column. Change the class on as many rows as you like and press Save class changes once, or tick a set of students (Tick all shown works with the Show filter and the search) and press Move ticked.
- Add from a list - paste email addresses, one per line or straight from a spreadsheet, or upload a CSV with an email column and optionally name and class columns. Everyone is added to your roster and put in their class in one go; classes the file names that do not exist yet can be created for you. Download a CSV template from the same tab.
- A student is in one class at a time: moving them takes them out of your other classes.

3. Building an assessment

Choose Create quiz. The page has two tabs: Quiz settings and Questions. You can move between them freely; nothing is lost until you publish or leave the page.

Quiz settings

- Quiz title - what students see on their dashboard.
- Time allowed - the countdown each student gets once they press Start. It runs from their own start time, not the clock.
- Passing score - the percentage needed to pass.
- Allow retakes - lets a student take the assessment more than once. Off by default.
- Show class average to students - reveals the class average alongside their own result.
- Randomize question order and Randomize answer order - shuffle per student, so neighbours do not see the same paper. True/False options are never shuffled.
- Opening and closing date and time - when the assessment is visible. Turn either off to leave that end open.

Note: Times are entered and shown in Central time (the label beside them says CDT or CST), whatever computer you use.

Audience

Assign to All gives the assessment to everyone currently on your roster, and to anyone who joins you later. Choose Students or Classes to be more specific.

Publishing

Press Publish quiz. If anything is missing - an untitled quiz, a question with no text, a correct answer that is not one of the options - the page lists exactly what to fix and nothing is saved.

Activating

A published assessment is inactive: no student can see it, whoever it is assigned to and whatever its opening time. When you want the class to take it, press Activate on your dashboard. The confirmation says how many students will see it and when it opens and closes, and warns you if the Description/Context seems to contain answers or an email address.

Deactivate hides it again straight away. Anyone already writing it can still hand in; nobody new can start. This is the safe way to take an assessment back - deleting it also deletes every attempt on it.

Note: The badge on each assessment says exactly who can see it: Inactive - hidden from students, Active - visible to students, Active - not open yet, or Active - closed.

4. Question types

Every question has a type, chosen from the dropdown above it.

Multiple choice

Up to four options, A to D, with exactly one correct answer. Leave an option blank to offer fewer than four; you need at least two.

Multiple choice - select all that apply

Same options, but the student picks any number of them. It is marked right only when their selection matches yours exactly - no partial credit.

True / False

Two fixed options. Pick which one is correct.

Fill in the blank and Short answer

The student types their answer into a box instead of picking from a list. The two behave identically; use whichever name reads better in your question. See the next section for how they are marked.

5. How typed answers are marked

Typed questions are marked automatically. Each one has an Answer type - Text or Number - which decides how forgiving the marking is.

Number answers

Use Number whenever the answer is a quantity. The system compares values, not characters, so 6, 6.0, 6.00, +6 and 12/2 are all the same answer.

How precise the student must be is taken from how precisely you wrote the answer:

- Write a whole number, such as 6, and only that exact value is accepted. 6.5 and 7 are wrong.
- Write 33.33 and anything within 0.005 is accepted - so 33.33, 33.333 and 100/3 all pass, while 33.3 does not.
- Write 2.5 and anything within 0.05 is accepted.

In short: the number of decimal places you type is the precision you are asking for. As you type, the line under the answer box shows the exact range that will be accepted, so you can check before publishing.

If you want a wider window, set Accept answers within under Marking options. For example, an answer of 100 with a tolerance of 5 accepts anything from 95 to 105.

Students see a matching hint under their answer box - Enter a whole number, or Round to 2 decimal places - so nobody has to guess.

Text answers

Capitals, surrounding spaces and trailing punctuation are always ignored, so paris, Paris and "Paris." all match Paris.

- Also accept - a comma-separated list of other answers you will take, for example USA, US, America.
- Forgive single-letter spelling slips - accepts an answer that is one letter away from the right one. It only applies to answers of four letters or more, so short answers are never guessed at.

Keeping the answer box sensible

The answer box is sized automatically from your answer - a two-digit number gets a small box. Set Limit the answer box to under Marking options to cap it yourself, which is a simple way to stop students writing an essay where a number belongs.

> *Note: Students never receive the correct answer in the page. Typed answers are marked on the server.*

6. Uploading a question bank

Instead of typing questions one at a time you can upload a .txt or .docx file - on Create quiz under Questions, or on an existing quiz under Manage. Choose Upload question bank, pick the file and press Read question bank.

Layouts it understands

- Numbered questions with lettered options and an answer key at the end - Answer Key: 1: A, 2: B, 3: A.
- Questions without numbers, the way a Moodle quiz looks when it is copied into Word - a line of text followed by options a. b. c. d. Lines such as Select one: are skipped.
- An answer under each question - ANSWER: B, or The correct answer is: Paris.
- The right option marked where it stands - a tick, highlight, bold, a different colour, (correct) or an asterisk. Marking only counts when it picks out some options and not the others, so a file with every option in bold is not read as all of them being right.

Checking what was read

You get a table of every question found, and the Answer from column says where each answer came from. Where the file does not say which option is right, Correct is left blank for you to fill in - the question is never dropped and the answer is never guessed - and the quiz will not publish until every question has one. Anything in the file that was not part of a question is listed under things to check.

Change any question's Type - including to a typed answer - and fix anything that reads wrong, then publish.

Description/Context

Tables in a .docx, with the sentence introducing them, become the quiz's Description/Context: the passage, case or data the questions refer to. Students see it above the questions while they work, and it is printed at the top of the PDF and DOCX downloads. You can also type or paste it yourself under Description/Context; a table is written one row per line, like | Net sales | $4,885,340 |.

> *Note: The Description/Context is part of the paper, so like the questions it is fixed once a real student starts.*

Read with AI

If the ordinary reader cannot follow a file's layout, Read with AI sends the file's text to OpenAI to read instead. It copies the answers your file marks and never works them out: an answer it cannot point to in the file is left blank for you. It usually takes a few seconds, and the result lands in the same table for you to check.

> *Note: Read with AI only appears once an OpenAI key has been set up. Do not use it on files that contain student names or other personal details.*

> *Note: Copy a Moodle quiz from its preview or edit page, not from a review page. A review page carries a student's answers and the marking feedback (You have correctly selected...), and anything left in the Description/Context is shown to every student. The upload leaves such lines out and warns you, and so does Activate.*

7. Assigning, scheduling and results

Changing who gets an assessment

Open Manage on a quiz, then Assign by students or classes. You can switch between All, specific students, and classes at any time.

While students are working

Analytics shows every student's status on a given exam - Not started, In progress or Completed - along with their score and last activity. The same table appears under Manage.

> *Note: Once a real student starts an assessment, its settings and its questions become read-only - including the order the questions are in. Your own preview attempts from Student view do not count.*

Students have to sit the same paper for their results to mean anything next to each other, so the paper is fixed the moment the first one starts. Get the questions right before you assign it - Student view lets you sit your own quiz and check it reads correctly.

> *Note: An answer key is the exception and stays correctable, because a mis-keyed question is a mistake rather than a change of paper, and fixing it alters nothing the student sees. Anyone still working is marked against the corrected key when they hand in; for results already recorded, use Regrade submitted attempts.*

To change the questions themselves after students have started, delete the assessment and publish a new one.

Downloads

- Download PDF - the paper itself with its Description/Context, optionally with the answer key and the quiz settings.
- Download results CSV - every assigned student with their class, status, score and result. The same file is on Analytics, under the exam's table: Download scores.
- Download gradebook (CSV), on Analytics - every student on your roster with their class and one column per assessment, holding their most recent submitted score.
- Download question bank CSV and Download printable DOCX - for editing or handing out on paper.

8. Previewing and troubleshooting

Student view shows the workspace exactly as a student sees it, and lets you take your own assessments to check they read correctly. These attempts are excluded from your analytics.

Common questions

- A student cannot see my assessment - check it is Active, that they are on your roster, that the quiz is assigned to them, and that the opening time has passed and the closing time has not.
- A student can see an assessment too early - press Deactivate. Never delete it to hide it: deleting throws away the work of anyone who has started.
- A student ran out of time - their answers are submitted automatically when the timer reaches zero, and whatever they had answered is marked.
- I need to fix a published question - if nobody has started it yet, open Manage, edit it and save. Once a student has started, only the answer key can change: correct it, then use Regrade submitted attempts for results already recorded. To change the question itself, delete the assessment and publish a new one.
- I unassigned a student who was halfway through - their unfinished attempt ends with the assignment, and nothing is recorded. Work they had already handed in is kept: unassigning someone never deletes a result.
- A student joined the wrong teacher - they can leave you from My teachers, and you can remove them from your roster.
- An upload found no questions - the message under the file says what it did contain and why nothing was read as a question. Check each question is followed by lettered options, or try Read with AI.